# ALEGRÍA DE CACAO
## *Chocolate-Amaranth Candy*

**makes one 8 × 8 pan**

Alegría, a candy made with popped amaranth seeds blended and set with honey, lives on in Mexico today and it's one you can imagine has been made in similar ways for centuries. This chocolate alegría is inspired by a version photographer David Alvarado brought me from Mexico City. I think it nicely honors the ancient Indigenous tradition of eating both amaranth and cacao.

- 2 cups Popped Amaranth (page 37) or store-bought
- ¼ cup pepitas
- 3 ounces unsweetened chocolate, coarsely chopped
- ½ Mexican vanilla bean, split lengthwise
- 3 tablespoons honey
- ⅛ teaspoon fine sea salt

Line an 8-inch square baking pan with parchment paper or wax paper that overhangs on two sides.

In a bowl, toss together the popped amaranth and pepitas.

Set a medium saucepan over medium-low heat. Add the chocolate and cook, stirring constantly, just until it starts to melt. Scrape in the vanilla seeds, stir in the honey and salt, and continue cooking until the chocolate is fully melted.

Pour the mixture over the amaranth and seeds and quickly stir until evenly coated. Scrape the coated amaranth into the prepared pan, use a spoon to press into an even layer, and let cool completely.

Use the paper overhang to lift and transfer the slab of the alegría to a cutting board. Cut it into 16 equal pieces (or cut how you like). Store in an airtight container for up to 5 days.

## AMARANTH: AN ANCIENT SUPERFOOD

Amaranth is one of those ingredients that shows the resilience of Indigenous peoples on Turtle Island. The tiny seeds—also thought of as a pseudo-cereal grain—are rich with protein and were an important food for people in Mesoamerica precolonization. In the Aztec empire, people built statues using amaranth and honey that were eaten during ceremonies. When Spanish conquistadors took over, they burned amaranth fields and forbade people from growing it—perhaps because of its use during non-Christian ceremonies.

As a major food crop, amaranth fell out of favor for centuries, although some people continued to grow it at a smaller scale and people continued to harvest the wild leaves. With its nutritional profile, amaranth seeds have been hailed as a superfood. The Mexican government has been actively promoting amaranth as a healthful addition to people's diets. Because it is a hardy plant and drought-resistant, it's also valuable as water becomes more scarce.

Amaranth can be cooked like a pilaf or risotto or ground into a flour for baking. It also is satisfying to eat popped. In fact, popped amaranth is used in many different sweets in Mexico, like this Alegría de Cacao.